

Customer communication and honest delivery estimates

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Authority: Simulated demo guidance. Primary source: *Dark Store Last-Mile Dispatch Playbook* (sample operations document, illustrative thresholds only), sections 4 and 6.

Applies to: Delay notices, delivery estimates, compensation credits, and customer message drafts.

Honest estimates

- Show customers an ETA based on current conditions, and never promise a time the data does not support.
- When an ETA can be supported, express it as a **range**, label it **estimate**, identify the relevant "as of" time/data basis where appropriate, and make clear it is not a promise.
- Never convert the ten-minute service promise or a stage target into a specific order's ETA.
- If no supported ETA is available, say that a reliable estimate cannot be provided from the available data. Acknowledge delay uncertainty without adding an unsupported number.
- Do not claim that a batch, radius change, call-in, or incentive will achieve a particular time or SLA result.

Proactive delay notice

The playbook calls for a proactive delay notice when an order passes 8 minutes in queue. Team decision: prepare the notice at 480 seconds or later. Use the order age from the live tool. The notice is a draft only and requires manager approval before sending.

Draft-only customer contact and credits

Customer notifications and compensation credits are drafted for the manager to approve before sending. A notice should be concise and respectful, acknowledge the delay, and include only a supported estimate, if one exists. It must not blame or pressure a rider, disclose internal personnel details, or promise a recovery time not backed by data.

Safe wording patterns

- **Supported range available:** "Your delivery is delayed. Current estimate: [tool-derived range]. This is an estimate, not a promise." Replace bracketed values only with approved calculation outputs.
- **No supported range:** "Your delivery is delayed. We are checking the latest dispatch information and will share an updated estimate when available."
- **Data stale or unavailable:** Do not present a stale estimate as current. Say the latest dispatch information is unavailable or timestamped and may be out of date; request manager review before any notice is sent.

These are templates, not authorization to message customers. Every communication remains a draft pending explicit manager approval.